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The final few days of March were an emotional rollercoaster for Italian sports fans.

First, Italian racer Kimi Antonelli became the youngest-ever Formula

One championship leader after winning back-to-back races in Shanghai and Japan. The following day, Jannik Sinner secured the Miami Open title to become the first man to complete the 'Sunshine Double' (Indian Wells and Miami Open) without dropping a single set.

Surely it could only get better, right? With the men's football team facing Bosnia and Herzegovina for a spot in the FIFA World Cup 2026, surely a party was brewing in the Southern European nation, right? Wrong.

All the elation from the previous days came crashing down as they watched their team take the lead, go

a man down, concede the lead and lose on penalties to a team ranked 53 spots below it in the FIFA rankings.

A reminder that football (locally known as Calcio) is the national sport of Italy. Moreover, it has won the World Cup four times, a tournament that it will now miss for the third straight time — a first for a former champion. A commanding win against Northern Ireland in the playoff semifinal would have instilled

confidence in Gennaro Gattuso's side, and Moise Kean's 15th-minute strike further strengthened its case.

However, a momentary lapse of judgement resulted in Alessandro Bastoni receiving his marching orders in the closing minutes of the first half, following which Bosnia started smelling blood. Gianluigi Donnarumma pulled out all the stops for the Italians with over 10 saves, but it proved futile as substitute Haris



For Italy, the wait to feature in FIFA World Cup will extend to at least 16 years now, with its last World Cup knockout match coming when it won the title in 2006.



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